

Chapter 113-4

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Liang Shi had challenged herself today.

She did something she would never have thought of normally—she held Xu Qingzhu while eating a meal. Although she didn't eat much, she would occasionally feed Xu Qingzhu while eating herself.

Xu Qingzhu, who was nearing her heat period, was unexpectedly clingy.

After finishing lunch, Xu Qingzhu even nestled in her arms for a while before leaving.

Although Liang Shi's body was satisfied, she couldn't help but worry in her heart.

She repeatedly reminded Xu Qingzhu to stay away from Alphas with strong pheromones, including Sally, Zhou Yi'an, and others, and to always keep suppressants on hand.

After saying all this, she asked if she had any with her. Seeing that she hadn't even brought her bag, she simply took her to a pharmacy to buy suppressants, and also bought a hot water bottle at a nearby mall.

Then she dropped her off at the company building.

As soon as Xu Qingzhu arrived downstairs at the company, she immediately transformed into a different person.

Her expression was cold and serious. She put the suppressants in her coat pocket and held the hot water bottle in her hand as if she were holding a six-figure handbag.

She told Liang Shi to drive carefully and got out of the car. Liang Shi kept watching her back, thinking she would turn around, but... she didn't.

Sure enough, Xu Qingzhu with work was not the same person as usual.

Liang Shi watched her walk into the building, then raised her hand to touch her own lips. She checked in the rearview mirror—the corner of her lip was broken.

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However, because of this lunch, Liang Shi's mood wasn't as heavy as it had been in the morning.

Instead, she felt energized, simply wanting to rescue Gu Xingyue from that cage.

As for Qi Jiao, only regret remained.

She checked the time. Because she and Xu Qingzhu had dawdled at the restaurant for so long—Xu Qingzhu had later sat on her lap playing on her phone, probably handling work matters.

Later, seeing that it was uncomfortable for her to eat, she changed to lying on her lap.

She had even taken a brief nap.

Kindergarten ended early. Because she needed to pick up Ling Dang, there wasn't enough time for Liang Shi to make a round trip to Angel Orphanage. She simply placed an order for same-city express delivery, then went to Xinhua Bookstore and bought a large pile of children's books. Only one was a novel—"The Storied Life of A.J. Fikry"¹.

She tucked the letter Gu Xingyue had given her inside "The Storied Life of A.J. Fikry" and had the courier deliver it to Gu Zhaoyuan.

At the same time, she called Gu Zhaoyuan to tell him about this.

Gu Zhaoyuan asked her if Gu Xingyue was doing well.

Liang Shi felt that simple terms like "well" or "not well" could no longer summarize Gu Xingyue's state. She could only express hope: "Anyway, things will definitely get better in the future."

Hearing this, Gu Zhaoyuan became dejected. "Alright, if there's an opportunity, please make sure to let me meet with her."

"I will." Liang Shi said, "First, read what she wrote in her letter to you. Her situation hasn't been very good recently. The family that adopted her is afraid she'll contact her former relatives, so I don't dare to rashly arrange a meeting between you two. It all depends on what she wants."

Gu Zhaoyuan expressed his understanding.

After hanging up, Liang Shi let out a breath. She took out Qi Jiao's diary from the compartment again.

Every entry was heartbreaking, the words revealing deep despair.

However, there were also entries filled with hope.

Those were when she mentioned Chen Mian.

【A new girl transferred into our class. She has shoulder-length hair. We all tie our hair in high ponytails, but only she wears her hair down. Underneath her black hair is a layer of gray. I really like that color—it's like darkness and light overlapping together. Her voice was also very pleasant when she introduced herself. Not only that, her name is also very nice. She's called—Chen Mian.】

【Chen Mian really likes painting. Like me, she doesn't like to talk much either. She's not pretty, and she doesn't stand out in a crowd. But I always secretly observe her.】

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Whenever Qi Jiao's diary mentioned Chen Mian, it was always from an observer's perspective. She recorded Chen Mian as she saw her, and also documented Chen Mian's daily life.

Qi Jiao said Chen Mian was a quiet weirdo, just like her. Although she wasn't pretty, in Qi Jiao's eyes, she was the special one.

As long as she was sitting there, Qi Jiao could only see her.

They didn't interact much in the beginning, but in the school library, the two of them met because they both reached for the same book.

It was the last copy in the library, and they had grabbed it almost simultaneously.

Qi Jiao naturally wanted to give it to her, but when she returned to the classroom, she found that book placed on her desk, while Chen Mian was lying on her desk sleeping.

If Qi Jiao had an inexplicable melancholic and sorrowful temperament, then Chen Mian had an arrogant and unrestrained roguish air about her.

Disdainful of the whole world.

Many of the things she painted were dark-themed. Many people who saw her for the first time only thought she was melancholic.

But only Qi Jiao saw the impatience with the world beneath her melancholic exterior.

The next day, Qi Jiao put a box of imported chocolates in her desk.

During break, Chen Mian bit into that chocolate, frowned and took two more bites, then placed the chocolate on the desk.

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1. "The Storied Life of A.J. Fikry" (《島上書店》, literally "The Island Bookstore") is a novel by Gabrielle Zevin about a bookstore owner on a small island. The Chinese title emphasizes the island bookstore setting. The book's famous quote "No man is an island" was referenced earlier in the story. ↩